Dale Nirvani Pfeifer.

CHAPTER 1, ON THE HOUSE

Why Judgment Is Becoming the Differentiator.

A free preview from the forthcoming book on AI and nonprofit fundraising.

How AI is reshaping the way fundraisers move from data to decisions to action, and why human judgment is becoming the most valuable asset on a development team.

FROM	Artificial Intelligence for Nonprofit Fundraising
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FROM THE CHAPTER

> AI did not change fundraising because it made tasks faster. It changed fundraising because it changed where judgment lives.

The full book publishes June 2026.
Pre-order, sample chapters, and the monthly dispatch:

aifundraisingfornonprofits.com

INSIDE THIS PREVIEW

What you will get from the next twelve pages.

The first chapter sets up the central argument of the book and the three workflow shifts redefining fundraising. It is short, practical, and built to be read in one sitting.

3

Workflow shifts that compress data, insight, and action into a single decision loop.

9%

Of nonprofits feel ready to use AI responsibly, even as 76 percent are already using it.

5

Key takeaways framing readiness as an organizational discipline, not an individual one.

1

Take Action exercise to do with your team before adopting any new AI tool.

> *AI did not change fundraising because it made tasks faster. It changed fundraising because it changed where judgment lives.*

From Chapter 1, the central argument.

CHAPTER ONE

Why Judgment Is Becoming the Differentiator

> *AI can help even rebalance the philanthropic ecosystem so the field isn't dominated by the most prominent, wealthiest nonprofits.*
>
> Jeff Raikes, former CEO of the Gates Foundation, and Dale Nirvani Pfeifer, "Reducing AI bias: A path forward"

Jordan's Story (Part 1)

A few weeks later, Jordan stepped out of the Denver conference hall with a racing pulse. She had gone to a conference to meet that solo development director and he had demonstrated a system that predicted which existing donors were most likely to lapse.

The development director had exported twelve months of donor data and the model flagged 312 at-risk donors and generated a personalized re-engagement email sequence. Before anything went out, he reviewed and edited each message to make sure it sounded like him (not his AI). The sequence included a short personalized email series, a targeted invitation to an upcoming program event, and a few well-placed impact metrics tied directly to the programs each specific donor had supported.

Within two weeks, open rates were up, responses were coming in, and donations were continuing. Early signs of disengagement had been interrupted. What struck Jordan most was not the sophistication of the technology but how accessible it was. What once required a data scientist and a team of interns had been prototyped by one person in an afternoon.

If a small, under-resourced nonprofit could move this quickly, Jordan knew her mid-sized nonprofit no longer had the luxury of waiting.

A Structural Shift in Fundraising

Jordan's story captures more than a clever use of AI. It signals a structural shift in fundraising. Today, lean teams with limited budgets can use AI to identify risk earlier, personalize outreach at scale, and make smarter decisions about where to focus scarce time and attention.

This shift presents both a significant opportunity and a clear wake-up call.

Across the global economy, AI adoption is accelerating rapidly. Between 2023 and 2024, private-sector usage jumped from 55 percent to 78 percent (Maslej et al. 2025). However, most nonprofits are still early in their AI adoption journey.

According to Nonprofit Tech for Good, the percentage of nonprofits that use AI in core fundraising workflows is: roughly 4.5 percent use smart donation forms, 4.1 percent use intelligent email sending, 2.3 percent use predictive donor segmentation, and just 1 to 2 percent use real-time or agentic AI in fundraising (Nonprofit Tech for Good 2026).

This disconnect exists because AI capability is advancing faster than most nonprofits' internal capacity building, budgets, and governance frameworks can keep up. Not because of resistance or lack of interest.

Fundraisers operate in trust-based environments, steward sensitive donor data, and serve communities where mistakes carry real human and reputational consequences. If AI personalization is done poorly, it can erode donor confidence faster than it is being built. In the absence of clear guidance and training, caution is not inertia; it is professional and ethical judgment.

Further evidence comes from the AI Equity Project 2025, which surveyed 850 nonprofits across the United States and Canada. While 76 percent of nonprofits reported using AI in some form, only 9 percent felt ready to use it responsibly, and just 15 percent had any AI governance or policy in place.

> While AI adoption is accelerating, only 9 percent of nonprofits feel ready to use AI responsibly. That disconnect tells us something important: AI is here, but organizations often lack the governance, training, and safeguards required for ethical and effective use.
>
> AI Equity Project, 2025

This reframes readiness as a shared responsibility. Fundraisers are often the first to see both the opportunity and the risk of AI in practice. Readiness is not about asking staff to “use AI more” but about supporting that work by providing clear guardrails, strengthening core data systems and data quality, defining acceptable use, and creating space for learning without fear of reputational risk.

Nonprofits that combine emerging AI capabilities with clear governance, training, and human judgment are best positioned. They are able to use these tools more deliberately, support fundraisers in their work, and strengthen relationships over time.

Historical Context: Technology Shifts in Fundraising

To understand why this technological shift feels so disruptive, it helps to zoom out. Fundraising has always been shaped by technology:

- Direct mail unlocked mass giving at scale.
- Email made donor communication faster and cheaper.
- Online giving platforms reduced friction and expanded reach.
- Social media brought virality and peer-to-peer momentum.

Each wave initially appeared as optional, then quickly became essential. AI is following a similar path, but with an important difference: it is not simply a new channel. Instead, it is integrated into all of our channels, reshaping how decisions are made.

The most consequential changes are not technological. They are behavioral.

Donor Mindset Shifts

Those behavioral shifts are showing up most clearly in how donors research, decide, and engage. As everyday consumer experiences become more personalized and responsive, donors carry those expectations into their giving.

Research reflects this change. Seventy-one percent of consumers now expect personalized interactions (McKinsey 2021), and more than 40 percent of donors say they would be willing to give or volunteer more when outreach feels genuinely tailored (Accenture 2017).

For nonprofits, the practical implications are that static segmentation and one-size-fits-all appeals are increasingly misaligned with donor expectations for timely, relevant communication. Teams that adapt will use personalization to strengthen relationships at scale, while those that do not risk falling out of sync with how donors now engage.

Three Workflow Shifts Redefining Fundraising Decisions

Rather than treating AI as a collection of features or platforms, this book focuses on how it reshapes the way fundraisers move from data to decisions to action. I have observed three major shifts across the sector.

1. Data → Insight (in Minutes)

AI can help deepen the data and insights in your donor database (referred to as your CRM). Pattern recognition models can flag donors who might stop giving or potentially upgrade their gifts. Insights that once took weeks of spreadsheet wrangling now appear in minutes through data visualizations on your dashboards. The payoff is strategic clarity: knowing who needs attention and why before campaigns even launch. Of course, this is only possible with accurate data, so invest in a verification process.

2. Insight → Action (at Scale)

Insight alone does not move money. What matters is how quickly teams can act on the newfound insight. For example, once a donor is flagged for risk, upgrade, or reactivation, the next step is no longer to rely on someone manually drafting emails or sorting through lists. AI-connected tools can generate message drafts, queue the outreach, and recommend the best outreach channel based on past behavior. These emails should be viewed as drafts only. Team members must review each email to ensure it is consistent in tone and accuracy.

3. Action → System → Strategy Loops

When action takes place consistently and at scale, it begins to form a system. And when that system learns from its own results, strategy changes. Each campaign generates feedback, such as opens, responses, gifts, and drop-offs, that can retrain models and refine future recommendations. Over time, teams stop reacting to lagging indicators and start steering with forward-looking signals, such as propensity scores (likelihood of repeat giving) and projected lifetime value (the total contribution a donor is likely to make over time).

At this point, AI shifts from being a helpful feature to a strategic lens, by shaping how priorities are set, resources are allocated, and donor relationships are stewarded over time.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

Five ideas to carry into your next planning conversation.

1. **AI isn't just a new tool. It changes how you work.**

   Most fundraising workflows have always had the same basic shape: find information, make sense of it, then act. AI compresses all three steps into one. That means faster decisions across the whole process, not just faster messaging.

2. **Speed without trust is risk.**

   AI enables faster, more personalized outreach, but only when paired with human judgment, transparency, and clear oversight.

3. **Fundraisers become stewards, not operators.**

   When AI handles the manual work, your team can focus on what donors actually value: good judgment, right timing, and real relationships.

4. **Readiness is organizational, not individual.**

   Successful adoption depends on shared guardrails, data discipline, and leadership support. Not asking fundraisers to "figure it out" on their own.

5. **Strategic advantage compounds over time.**

   When insight, action, and learning are connected, each campaign makes the next one smarter. Fundraising shifts from reactive to predictive.

TAKE ACTION

Before choosing any tools, pause and align with your team.

This reflection sets the foundation for responsible experimentation and prevents speed from outpacing trust. Bring it to your next team meeting and work through the three prompts together.

Team alignment exercise

~ 30 MINUTES

01 Name one part of your fundraising workflow that currently relies on instinct or lagging data, for example, who to re-engage, when to follow up, or how to prioritize limited staff time.

02 Identify the points in that decision where judgment must remain human, to protect donor trust, tone, and values.

03 Document one guardrail your nonprofit would need in place before applying AI to that decision, for example, human review, consent clarity, or data limits.

> *As a tool, AI only works as well as the data and rules that surround it.*

The chapters that follow focus on the practical foundations nonprofits need in place so that AI can support fundraising work rather than complicating it. Next, in Chapter 2, we tackle data foundations and governance for ethical AI.

WANT THE REST?

The full book publishes June 2026.

Eleven case studies, real teams, specific results. A practical playbook for fundraisers and nonprofit leaders who carry both responsibility and care.

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Dale is the CEO of Giving Compass, a philanthropic intelligence platform reaching more than two million donors annually. She co-founded Goodworld, the technology behind the #donate hashtag, and writes on AI and philanthropy with leaders including Jeff Raikes, former CEO of the Gates Foundation.

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